



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Padre Pio
School Website: <https://www.chestertonsarasota.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Padre Pio (Sarasota, FL) presents a robust classical-Catholic model, consistently aligning with the six elements of classical education. Public materials emphasize a Catholic cultural core (Mass, prayer, liturgy, and daily worship) alongside a liberal-arts curriculum shaped by the Great Books tradition, Socratic dialogue, and memory-based pedagogy. The school frames its mission as formation of virtue and wisdom rather than mere information or workforce preparation, with explicit reference to Formation, Virtue, and the Cultivation of the True, Good, and Beautiful. The faculty is depicted as experienced and aligned with a living-curriculum approach, and the community actively engages parents through informational sessions, open houses, and family involvement. Public materials also highlight the school's internal culture—House system, daily Mass, and a pilgrim-facing formation that ties academic study to Catholic faith and Western civilizational heritage.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Strong CLASSICAL signals (Catholic daily life, Incarnation-centered pedagogy, liturgical practices, Mass, prayer, sacred music, liturgy, and theology support). Evidence: Catholic culture as the heartbeat of daily life; Incarnation-centered education; Mass at school; daily ritual and sacred elements.
- Purpose and Goal: Strong CLASSICAL signals (formation of virtue and wisdom, contemplation, and a telos aligned with truth, goodness, and beauty). Evidence: formation-focused language, Culture Vitae, humane formation of leaders/saints.
- Curriculum: Strong CLASSICAL signals (liberal arts framework; grammar/logic/rhetoric emphasis; Great Books/Western canon; history-integrated approach; emphasis on wonder). Evidence: humanities program braided with Socratic method; classical literature including Homer, Dante, Shakespeare; Latin/Greek offerings; integration of history, philosophy, theology.
- Pedagogy: Strong CLASSICAL signals (Socratic dialogue, memorization/recitation, contemplative/restful elements, and rhetoric in upper levels). Evidence: Socratic seminars; "Learning Through Dialogue"; memory and chant/memorization/repetition; discussion-based pedagogy.
- Faculty: Strong CLASSICAL signals (experienced faculty, "headmaster" leadership, living-curriculum orientation, mentors, and portrait of teachers). Evidence: Headmaster with long record; biographies illustrating virtuous leadership and professional formation; faculty involvement in school culture.
- Parents & Community: Strong CLASSICAL signals (partnership with families, open campus visits, parent formation, community events). Evidence: multiple parent information sessions, open houses, prospective-parent nights, and family involvement language.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials present Catholic daily living as central to education, with Mass, prayer, and liturgical life as “the heartbeat” of the school culture.
 - Formation around Incarnation and a theologically grounded curriculum is explicit (Incarnation as central event; catechesis present in curriculum).
 - Liturgical practices and sacred culture are integrated (Daily Mass; liturgical calendar cues; sacred music references).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Catholic, Mass, prayer, liturgy, Mass, Incarnation, theology, sacred, reverence, wonder, beauty, virtue, Logos.
 - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials.
 - Estimated usage: at least 9+ positive terms cited across materials; 0 negative indicators found.
- Why this rating
 - The school explicitly centers education in Catholic theological and liturgical foundations and presents a sacramental, transcendent frame for learning, which squarely aligns with CLASSICAL expectations in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Formation of virtue and wisdom is stated as a primary aim, not merely information or job prep (formation language; “joyful leaders and saints,” “formation of human excellence”).
 - The curriculum is framed around liberal education and the perfection of the human person (great conversation and contemplation in the long view of education).
 - The school’s motto and culture (Cultura Vitae; Culture of Life) link education to durable, transcendent goods.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, contemplation, scholé, great conversation, human excellence, moral imagination, culture of life.
 - Negative keywords present: none observed (no emphasis on workforce- or job-readiness language in place of formation).
 - Estimated usage: high positive presence; negligible to zero negative indicators.
- Why this rating
 - The school emphasizes formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty—core aims of classical education’s telos. This strongly supports CLASSICAL across this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Liberal arts framework highlighted (grammar, logic, rhetoric; humanities; form of study across disciplines). The Three Pillars describe Intellect, with the goal of teaching the classics and the interrelationship of great ideas.
 - The Humanities Program braids history, literature, philosophy, theology, and foreign languages (Latin/Spanish) with the Socratic Method.
 - Study includes classical epics and canonical authors (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, Chesterton) and a linked history-literature approach.
 - Explicit Great Books/Primary-source orientation and memorability through recitation and classical rhetoric appear in materials.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classical canon, Western civilization, Latin/Greek, history, Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Chester-

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- ton, Socratic Method, memorization/recitation.
 - Negative keywords present: no explicit social-studies-first framing; no project-based-dominant language observed.
 - Estimated usage: high density of positive curriculum signals; minimal to no negative signals.
 - Why this rating
 - The materials show a classical-canon approach with liberal-arts structure, Great Books orientation, and an integrated, history-facing curriculum, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Socratic seminar and dialogue-based pedagogy are central (The Humanities Program uses the Socratic Method).
 - Memorization/recitation and singing/chanting memory work are part of the traditional pedagogy (memory work; chant; liturgical repetition texts appear in the lexicon).
 - The approach includes contemplative/restful elements (Scholé) and structured discipline in rhetoric and oratory (upper-school) with opportunities for public speaking.
 - The House system and formation through dialogue and debate are described as core components, including rhetoric and public speaking opportunities.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar, dialogue, questioning, dialectic, narration, recitation, chanting, singing, Scholé, memory work, rhetoric, speech, declamation, debate, public speaking, great conversation.
 - Negative keywords present: minimal or no explicit emphasis on exclusively experiential or project-based/constructivist methods in these public materials.
 - Estimated usage: robust presence of positive pedagogy terms; negative signals appear negligible.
- Why this rating
 - The public materials show a classical pedagogy mix of Socratic inquiry, memorization, chant, and rhetoric training, which aligns with CLASSICAL norms for teaching methods.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Headmaster (Jerome Scarcella) is profiled as a veteran, virtuous educator leading the school, with explicit emphasis on a Christ-centered, mentor-like leadership style.
 - Faculty are depicted as living models who contribute to formation and the culture (e.g., teacher biographies, long-tenured staff, and faculty involvement in shaping school life).
 - The public materials describe the faculty as the core of the school's mission and community (formation, mentorship, partnership with families).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty as core, headmaster, faculty biographies, Christ-centered leadership.
 - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials.
 - Estimated usage: multiple explicit mentions of classical-faculty signals; few or no negative signals.
- Why this rating
 - The materials depict a veteran, virtue-centered faculty, with leadership that reinforces the school's classical aims, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for Faculty.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

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- The school actively markets parent-facing events and information sessions (Open House, Informational Meetings, Prospective Parent Nights).
 - There are clear structures for parent involvement and co-teaching/co-learning with families (parent formation, family information sessions, opportunities to meet teachers and view curriculum).
 - Community engagement is evident through founder campaigns, family outreach, and a culture of welcoming visits and tours (Open House, Shadow Days, Information Meetings).
 - Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, open campus, family engagement, parent involvement, community support.
 - Negative keywords present: none observed (no consumer-only language; no minimal parent involvement cues).
 - Estimated usage: substantial presence of parental-community terms; negligible negative signals.
 - Why this rating
 - The school demonstrates active, ongoing engagement with parents and community, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
- Rationale: Across all six categories, Chesterton Academy of St. Padre Pio demonstrates sustained classical-core indicators: a Catholic worldview integrated with a liberal-arts curriculum; a pedagogy centered on Socratic dialogue, memorization, and the cultivation of virtue; a teaching force positioned as mentors and living curriculum; and ongoing parent/community partnerships that align with classical tradition.
- Notes on the school's public materials:
 - Catholic enculturation is explicit (Mass, Incarnation, liturgy, catechesis, Catholic culture as heart of daily life). This grounds the religious foundation strongly.
 - The curriculum explicitly ties to liberal-arts formation, Great Books, and integrated humanities using Socratic method.
 - Pedagogy emphasizes the Socratic method, memory work, and rhetoric, layered with contemplative elements.
 - Faculty leadership and the living-curriculum concept are evident through headmaster biographies and staff descriptions.
 - Parent/community involvement is actively cultivated via informational events and open-campus offerings.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable, as the aggregate is CLASSICAL.
- If the school sought to intensify CLASSICAL alignment further, potential steps could include explicit references to Great Conversation language in more public materials, more direct articulation of Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in curricular pages, and explicit integration of the Quadrivium in course descriptions. However, current materials already reflect a robust classical orientation.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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